Shooting mechanic playtest

Facilitator guide • Keep this page out of the player's view

Find out whether new players discover that shooting can open a door, stun an enemy, and create steps to climb a wall. Record what they do before you explain the mechanic. Copy pages 2 and 3 for each player; use page 4 to compare results.

Before testing

Team _____Keiser Games_____V0.3_- Build or date ____11/11/2026_____

Test the current build once. Identify the door lock, enemy, frosting wall, and exact destination for each task. Check that each interaction works. Record any missing or broken feature rather than treating it as player failure.

Use the same task order, starting locations, controls, and starting ammunition for everyone. Reset the door, enemy, wall steps, and player state between sessions. Give every player access to the weapon. Record any earlier exposure to a mechanic.

Locations and destinations Door _____1_at beginning of level._____ Enemy _____4 enemies in total 2 in the beginning, one on the bottom level and one later on in the level._____
Wall _____2_walls one at the beginning of the level and one at the end_____ Starting equipment and ammo _____Loaded: 6 and Reserve:8_____

What to say to the player

"We are testing the game to see what needs improving. You can stop at any time. Please play as you normally would and, if comfortable, tell us what you are trying to do. I will mostly watch. Is it okay for us to take anonymous notes?"

Use a participant code. Avoid names and contact details. Follow your class rules for storing and deleting notes. Ask separately before any audio or video recording.

Tasks and help rule

Task prompt to read aloud	Observer success check and standard hint
Door: "Get to the other side of this door."	Check: shoots the lock, opens the door, and passes through. Hint: "Try shooting the lock."
Enemy: "Get past this enemy to the marked destination."	Check: shoots the enemy and makes it pause. Record whether the player also passes it, including any bypass. Hint: "Try shooting the enemy."
Wall: "Reach the top of this wall."	Check: shoots the frosting wall to create steps and uses them to reach the top. Hint: "Try shooting the wall to make steps."

Suggested class rule: start a new timer when each task begins. At 60 seconds, give the standard hint if the target use has not succeeded. Stop at 120 seconds, on success, or when the player wants to stop. Agree on any changes before testing and use them for everyone.

Use neutral prompts such as "What are you trying to do?" Log every hint, control explanation, demonstration, reset, or interruption. Keep built-in game instructions visible and note which ones the player notices.

Participant session record

Observer page • One copy per player • Keep the success checks hidden

Participant code :0001_____ Observer: Colton Keiser_____ Date: 11/11/2026__ _____
Game or team: NinjaFrogPlatformer _____ Build:V0.3_____ Device :Mouse&Keyboard_____

Anonymous notes agreed? [X] **Yes** [ ] No — stop collecting notes
Prior experience with this build: [X] **None** [ ] Watched it [ ] Played it
Platformer experience: [X] **None** [ ] Occasional [ ] Frequent
Control device familiarity: [X] **New** [ ] Some [ ] Comfortable
Optional setup or access needs relevant to play _____N/A_____

Timing and outcome codes

Agreed hint time ___30___ seconds Task cutoff ___90___ seconds Task order ___1_____

U = target use succeeds before any outside help. A = target use succeeds after help. I = target use does not succeed by the stop time. NR = not reached or not testable; explain why. A bypass does not count as discovery of the target use.

Record discovery at the first purposeful attempt to use shooting for this effect. Note the action or quote that supports it. An accidental hit alone does not establish understanding. Times below are elapsed from the start of each task; use “not observed” when needed.

Door

Starting state or earlier exposure _____First time seeing door, weapon was place infront of it. _____

First purposeful attempt at ___10___ s [X] Before help [ ] After help [ ] Not observed
Evidence of discovery _____After shooting a couple test shots finally hit the keyhole and unlocked the door. _____

Shoots the lock and opens the door: [X] Yes [ ] No Time _____ s
Passes through the door: [X] Yes [ ] No Time _____ s

First help at ___0___ s [X] None Help or deviation _____
Target use outcome: [X] U [ ] A [ ] I [ ] NR Task stop time _____ s
If bypassed, incomplete, or NR, explain _____Completed as intended_____

Enemy

Starting state or earlier exposure _____First time seeing enemy; after the wall encounter._____

First purposeful attempt at ___45___ s [ ] Before help [ ] After help [ ] Not observed
Evidence of discovery _____Jumped around enemy a bit and landed on its head, eventually lined up a shot and stunned it. _____

Shoots the enemy and causes a stun: [X] Yes [ ] No Time _____ s
Reaches the marked destination: [X] Yes [ ] No Time _____ s

First help at __0____ s [X] None Help or deviation _____
Target use outcome: [X] U [ ] A [ ] I [ ] NR Task stop time _____ s
If bypassed, incomplete, or NR, explain _____ Completed as intended_____

Wall

Starting state or earlier exposure _____First time seeing after the door encounter; _by second wall had ran out of ammo_____

First purposeful attempt at __25____ s [X] Before help [ ] After help [ ] Not observed
Evidence of discovery _____

Creates steps by shooting the wall: [ ] Yes [ ] No Time _____ s
Uses the steps to reach the top: [ ] Yes [ ] No Time _____ s

First help at __0____ s [X] None Help or deviation _____
Target use outcome: [X] U [ ] A [ ] I [ ] NR Task stop time _____ s
If bypassed, incomplete, or NR, explain __Completed as intended_____

Observation log and player feedback

Participant code ____0001_____ • Attach extra log pages if needed

What happened during play

Write one event per row. Describe visible actions. Put the player's exact words in quotation marks. Keep possible explanations in the interpretation space below. Include help, reload trouble, bugs, and accidental successes.

Task and elapsed time	Observed action or exact quote	Help given or technical issue
Movement: 0:00 - :30	User who was new to mouse and keyboard movement struggled to identify the movement keys on the keyboard. They believed the mouse would be a factor in movement as it was how they navigated the beginning menu.	I instructed them on W,A,S,D movement.
Shooting: :30 – 1:00	User struggled with identifying how to shoot the weapon as they assumed it would've been another keyboard key.	I eventually instructed that it would be the left Mouse button.
Ammo: 1:30 – 1:58	The user run out of all ammo by the time they hit the second wall. As they liked shooting the enemies and spent all their ammo doing that.	May consider adding more ammo or more ammo refill stations throughout map so player can not get stuck.

Questions after all three tasks

Ask these after play so the questions do not reveal the later tasks. Record the player's answers, including when they do not remember.

1. What did you think shooting could do when you first found the weapon?

___I was surprised that shooting could interact with the different obstacles. My assumption when encountering the enemies was that shooting would incapcitate them permanently and not give a short stun._____

2. What helped you work out what to do at the door, enemy, and wall?

_By messing around with the keybinds and having nothing else to do but shoot the obstacles in the way. _Having one of the obstacles have a keyhole helped figure it out.

_____

_____

3. Where did you get stuck, and what did you expect to happen?

_____I got stuck after fully running out of ammo between the two wall obstacles.

_____

_____

4. How clear was what to do at each obstacle? Circle one per row.
1 = very unclear 2 = unclear 3 = neither clear nor unclear 4 = clear 5 = very clear
Door: 1 2 3 **4** 5 / not reached Enemy: 1 2 3 **4** 5 / not reached
Wall: 1 2 3 **4** 5 / not reached

Door : 4

Enemy: 4

Wall: 3

Observer interpretation after the session

Possible explanation, linked to an event above ____The player noted for door and enemy a 4 as the door has a keyhole and the enemy was interesting to shoot at. Thus they were more intuitive to figure out. While shooting at the wall to make steps was slightly less easy to figure out probably due to the lack of visual indicators.
_____
_____

Alternative explanation or uncertainty _____The players thought process could have been different in interpreting these encounters. Perhaps the player just innately considered certain obstacles more intuitive than others._____
_____

Team results and next test

Complete after testing • Keep participant records as evidence

Team _____Keiser Games_____ Build: V.03_____ Number of players 3_____
Shared setup, hint time, cutoff, and deviations _____

_____

Results across players

Enter U, A, I, or NR from each session record. Add rows if you test more players.

Player code	Door	Enemy	Wall	Relevant experience or deviation
0001	U	A	I	No platformer exp.; new controls; ammo ran out before wall 2 (actual)
0002	U	A	I	Frequent platformer; simulated
0003	U	A	i	Occasional platformer; simulated

For each task, tested = U + A + I. Keep NR separate. Report counts and denominators. Use the observation logs to check whether help, earlier tasks, or technical problems affected the results.

Target use	U / tested	A / tested	I / tested	NR count
Door	3 / 3	3 / 3	3 / 3	3
Enemy stun*	3 / 3	3 / 3	3 / 3	3
Wall steps*	3 / 3	3 / 3	3 / 3	3

Two findings supported by evidence

1. What did you learn? _____ The blowdart may be seen as an enemy weapon before players realize it also affects the level. _____
Player codes and event times or quotes _____0001 expected permanent enemy incapacitation and said the keyhole helped. 0002 expected an attack; 0003 relied on hints. _____
How did this affect play? _____Players approach the obstacles and level with different levels of expectations due to the fact they had a weapon. _____
Alternative explanation or limitation ____It may not have been obvious or well explained to the player the darts could interact with the level._____

2. What did you learn? _____ The wall-step interaction may be less obvious, and ammunition can block progress.
_____
Player codes and event times or quotes _____ 0001 rated wall clarity 3/5 and ran out of ammo before wall 2. 0002 found the wall slowest; 0003 rated it 2/5 and needed a hint. _____
How did this affect play? _____ Players may miss that shooting creates steps; spending darts earlier may leave too few for later obstacles. _____
Alternative explanation or limitation _____The level fails to showcase this to the player through text or design layout._____

One change and a retest plan

Priority change _____Having more opportunities for the player to refill their ammo.
_____
Evidence supporting it _____The player running out of ammo by accident by the second wall._____
What will change in the next build? _____The next build will have more refill stations for player ammo.
_____
What outcome would show improvement? _____The player more consistently being able to finish the level with less confusion. _____
Fresh players and conditions to keep consistent _____Enemy and obstacle placement
_____

Describe this sample accurately: “__2_ of _3__ tested players used shooting to __Navigate the level_____ without help.” Consider prior experience, task order, hints, and bugs. Small classroom samples cannot establish what all players will do.